weeks a year, is composed of 47 elected United Nations member states who serve for an initial period of three years, and cannot be elected for more than two consecutive terms. The Human Rights Council is empowered to prevent abuses, inequity and discrimination, protect the most vulnerable, and expose the perpetrators.

The Human Rights Council is different from OHCHR as both have separate mandates given by the General Assembly. Nevertheless, the OHCHR provides, substantive support for the meetings of the Human Rights Council, and follow-up to the Council's deliberations.

The **Universal Periodic Review** (UPR) is a process by which a review of the human rights records of all the member states of the UN is done once in every four years.

Special Procedures constitute the mechanisms established by the Commission on Human Rights and assumed by the Human Rights Council after its creation in 2006 to address either specific country situations or thematic issues in all parts of the world. Special Procedures are either an individual—a special rapporteur or representative of the Secretary General, or an independent expert—or a working group.

Special Procedures' mandates usually call on mandate-holders to examine, monitor, advise and publicly report on human rights situations in specific countries or territories, known as **country mandates**, or on major phenomena of human rights violations worldwide, known as **thematic mandates**. There are 30 thematic mandates and 8 country mandates. All report to the Human Rights Council on their findings and recommendations. They are sometimes the only mechanism that will alert the international community on certain human rights issues.

There are nine core international human rights treaties, two of which —on persons with disabilities and enforced disappearance—have not yet come into force. Since the adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights in 1948, all UN member states have ratified at least one or more of core international human rights treaty.

There are eight human rights **treaty-based bodies** which are committees of independent experts that monitor implementation of